

Creative Coding 1 — MART 120

Syllabus, Fall 2026

MART 120, Section 50

Instructor: Grace Smith **Office Hours:** Thursdays, 3-5 pm, or by appointment **E-mail:** gs172738@umconnect.umt.edu **Discord:** <https://discord.gg/Ua4nYdfu4S> **Canvas:** <http://canvas.umt.edu/>

Overview

Creative Coding I is an introductory programming course for Media Artists, with no prerequisites. In this course, we create games, art, and digital representations using various visual and written programming languages. We also study how our mindset influences our art and our formed expressions.

Explore digital art in a new and exciting way through computer programming. Blend the traditional with technology to create something new. Learn that programming is an art form and how graphical visualizations integrate with many disciplines. As an introductory course, it is meant to get you excited about the possibilities of what programming can do for you. Anyone is welcome, and we interact online in new ways to enhance each other's art and engagement.

Topics covered: general computing concepts, logical reasoning and critical thinking, and multiple programming paradigms.

Upon completing this course, a student will be able to:

- Gain experience with programming constructs
 - Analyze different programmatic techniques
 - Create digital art using programming languages
 - Create simple games using programming languages
 - Demonstrate online presentation skills using current online collaboration tools
 - Gain experience with an online repository
 - Build increased communication skills
 - Gain experience critiquing and incorporating feedback from others online
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Attendance

Attendance is not mandatory; however, it is your responsibility to make up any missed work.

Grading

Component	Weight
Homework	60%
Final Project/Portfolio	40%

Final Portfolios/Project due: Friday, Dec 11th, 2026, 11:59 PM

All assignments are submitted through Canvas. If you have trouble submitting, email them to gs172738@umconnect.umn.edu with the subject line "MART 120 Assignment #" (e.g., "MART 120 Assignment 1").

Grading Scale

Grade	Range
A	93–100
A-	90–92
B+	87–89
B	84–86
B-	80–83
C+	77–79
C	74–76
C-	70–73
D+	64–66
D	60–63
D-	59 and below

F —

P/NP (pass/no pass): 70 or greater is passing, per Media Arts Department policy (equivalent to a C or better).

Late Assignments

Late assignments are automatically recorded as a zero in Canvas. If you'd still like to submit, I'll accept it for up to one week for a 10% deduction; after that, it will remain a zero. To submit late, email it to gs172738@umconnect.umt.edu with the subject line 'MART 120 Assignment #' (e.g., 'MART 120 Assignment 1'). That said, if something comes up, an emergency or otherwise, please reach out, and I'm always willing to work with you.

Requirements

Required Texts: None. Readings will be assigned, but there is no textbook.

Prerequisites: None.

Software:

- Visual Studio Code or Atom (or any other editor)
- GitHub Desktop or Command Line
- Scratch

Suggestions: Ask as many questions as you can, and feel free to set up an appointment if you need help. I am here to help you understand and do well.

Collaboration

You are encouraged to work together through problems; note who you worked with at the top of the page, but copying and plagiarism will not be tolerated. If you are caught cheating, you will receive an F for the course.

Please refer to the Student Conduct Code:

https://www.umt.edu/campus-life/community-standards/um_student_code_of_conduct.pdf

I fully acknowledge that you will, and expect you will, integrate Generative AI into your work. However, I also ask that you reflect on what you created versus what was created by an AI model, and discern its usefulness and why you used it.

Incompletes

An incomplete for the course is not an option to be exercised at the discretion of students. In all cases, it is given at the discretion of the instructor. Guidelines for receiving an incomplete include having a passing grade up to three weeks before the end of the semester and being in attendance. Negligence and indifference are not acceptable reasons. Note there may be financial aid implications. A contract between the student and instructor will be created, acknowledging what needs to be completed along with due dates.

Late Drops

The University's policy on drops after 45 days of instruction is very specific, and the School of Visual and Media Arts follows it rigorously. Five circumstances under which a late drop might be approved: registration errors, accident or illness, family emergency, change in work schedule, and no assessment of performance in class after this deadline. Except in unusual circumstances, late drops will only be approved with documented justification for one of these circumstances.

Land Acknowledgement

The Séliš-Qłispé Cultural Committee created the following language: "The University of Montana acknowledges that we are in the aboriginal territories of the Salish and Kalispel people. Today, we honor the path they have always shown us in caring for this place for the generations to come."

Inclusion Policies

The University of Montana values leadership, engagement, diversity, and sustainability because our institution is committed to respecting, welcoming, encouraging, and celebrating our differences. As members of the University of Montana community, we aspire to:

- Respect the dignity and rights of all persons
- Practice honesty, trustworthiness, and academic integrity
- Promote justice, learning, individual success, and service
- Act as good stewards of institutional resources
- Respect the natural environment

The College of the Arts and Media has chosen to actively pursue equity and access for all persons. In this charge, we will research, plan, and implement ways in which our culture can be more accessible, inclusive, equitable, and sustainable. It is necessary to be anti-bias in principle to be equitable in action. These actions will be implemented on an ongoing basis, organized by a group of students, faculty, and staff across the entire college.

Student Support Resources

Academic Misconduct and the Student Conduct Code: This Code of Conduct embodies and promotes honesty, integrity, accountability, and duties associated with citizenship as a student in our community at the University of Montana. It exists to protect the interests of the community and the dignity of its members and to challenge behaviors not in accordance with our policies. Available at:

https://www.umt.edu/campus-life/community-standards/um_student_code_of_conduct.pdf

Accommodations: Students with disabilities may request reasonable modifications by contacting the Office of Disability Equity (ODE). The University of Montana assures equal access to instruction through collaboration between students with disabilities, instructors, and ODE. More information: <http://www.umt.edu/disability>

Writing and Public Speaking Center: Provides one-on-one tutoring to students at all levels and at any point in the writing process. www.umt.edu/writingcenter

Mental Health and Well-being Policy: The University of Montana is committed to advancing the mental health and well-being of its students. Many students experience personal challenges that can impact their academic learning, and many services are available on campus to support student success inside and outside the classroom. If you or someone you know is feeling overwhelmed, depressed, and/or in need of additional support, visit:

<https://www.umt.edu/well-being/student-resources/default.php>

Our Well-being Support Coordinator can help you navigate resources: fill out this form (https://umt.co1.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_cTq1BO0XyqpXTAG) or contact her directly (<https://calendly.com/courtney-bowers>).

Stay Connected: Join SVMA on social media for events and happenings in our school.

- Instagram: https://www.instagram.com/umt_svma/

- Facebook: <https://www.facebook.com/UMTsvma>
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Class Etiquette

- Be respectful of your fellow classmates.
 - Message me anytime if you have a question.
 - Profanity and obscenity will not be tolerated in class or assignments.
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Special Dates

- **Aug 24, 2026** — First Day of Class
- **Sept 7, 2026** — Labor Day, no class
- **Oct 12, 2026** — Indigenous Peoples' Day, no class
- **Nov 11, 2026** — Veterans Day, no class
- **Nov 23 and Nov 25, 2026** — no class
- **Nov 26–27, 2026** — Fall Break
- **Dec 4, 2026** — Last Day of Classes
- **Dec 7–11, 2026** — Finals Week

Week	Date	Learning Topic / Activities
Week 1	Aug 24 - Sept 30	Syllabus/Github
Week 2	Sept 31 - Sept 6	Code.org
Week 3	Sept 7 - Sept 13	Scratch
Week 4	Sept 14 - Sept 20	Game and App Lab

Week 5	Sept 21 - Sept 27	Snap
Week 6	Sept 28 - Oct 4	HTML
Week 7	Oct 5 - Oct 11	CSS
Week 8	Oct 12 - Oct 18	JavaScript
Week 9	Oct 19 - Oct 25	p5.js Introduction
Week 10	Oct 26 - Nov 1	p5.js Simple Shapes
Week 11	Nov 2 - Nov 8	p5.js Conditionals, Loops, Event Handling
Week 12	Nov 9 - Nov 15	p5.js Functions
Week 13	Nov 16 - Nov 22	p5.js Arrays
Week 14	Nov 23 - Nov 29	Fall Break
Week 15	Nov 30 - Dec 6	Work on Final Projects
Week 16	Dec 7 - Dec 11	Work on Final Projects